

A Love Story

In Sandra Cisneros's book *The House on Mango Street*, a young Esperanza describes her name. "In English my name means hope. In Spanish it means too many letters. It means sadness, it means waiting." She goes on to describe the grandmother she was named after, the qualities she possesses and lacks, and the names and nicknames she wishes she had. So very much is shared about who this young woman is, simply by sharing the meanings, emotions, and imagery behind her name.

This search for purpose and identity isn't new to young adult literature, and it's also not new to the people of the Text.

What makes me, me?

What makes me, *me*?

Those things that embrace my identity, my purpose, and, for many of us reading this, the calling and promise of a loving God.

Many things are integrally woven into the names of the people in the Text, so when the story pauses and the names are written, we better pay attention. What an individual is called appears to be a blessing, or a curse, to live up to. (And I have so many wonderings about why certain names were chosen or given even in retrospect.)

We see Naomi's identity intricately tied to her name (*pleasant*), with how Ruth notices her distinct goodness and holds onto it with all that she has. Elle challenges all of us to live up to this calling, this name, that we may be "so full of God, so full of light, that the people who encounter us and meet us and get to know us don't want to go anywhere else because they say, 'I know you have the living water and I'm thirsty.'"

"I know you have the living water and I'm thirsty."

Naomi even goes so far as to change her name as she feels the promises of God have, quite bitterly, fallen short—but in the end, her true name, or promise, wins out. Just as she did, we do have a choice in how we embrace our name.

When naming my children, the meanings behind their names played an important part in the decisions. When choosing my daughter's, we stumbled across two family names that we quickly fell in love with.

Amedee is a family name meaning "love God" in French, and *Ruth* meaning "neighbor" or "good friend" in Hebrew.

We gave our daughter the Jesus *Shema* as a name. Love God. Love others.

I never thought one person could wholly live their name so well—at least so far in her own story—and also be a daily reminder to do so myself. Like Ruth, my little girl is such a good friend, a good neighbor. There are never too many friends, never too many people, and never too many animals to love—fiercely. God stamped her name on her heart, and I was lucky enough to call her that. Yet, when things are hard, friends on the playground betray her, or selfishness rears its head, I hope to give her tools like these three things:

- 1) Hold onto something good**
- 2) Ignore the voices that distract or destroy**
- 3) Seek out a beacon of strength and hope**

God reminds us through the powerful relationships in the book of Ruth that we don't have to go it alone. In the midst of great tragedy and loss and anger, Ruth, and others throughout the Text, do these three things; none of them can happen in isolation.

Maybe that is part of this love story. Not just the love story of Ruth and Boaz. Not just the love story of a mother and daughter. Not just the love story of a man treating his neighbor well, but a love story to show us we are not only created in His image to *look* a certain way but to *live* it—the calling and promise to love as He does is written on our hearts and minds, within our very identities.

May we each live up to the meaning of our names—not necessarily the ones given to us by parents at birth or we sign on official documents—but the ones that God has written on our hearts. That identity. That purpose. That promise.

PRAYER

*Shaddai,
Make me more like You
full of Your light, a good neighbor, a good friend.
And may I cling to You with chutzpah, never letting go.
Help me push aside the voices of bitterness
that seek to drown out your words.
May I seek you in grief, anger, pain, or isolation,
Joy, peace, purpose, or belonging.
For You are my beacon of hope.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

If you haven't yet, go read the whole book of Ruth. What else do you notice? Other names, other questions, or details that stick out. What might the Text be showing us?



COMMUNITY

How do the relationships of Naomi and Ruth, or Ruth and Boaz, challenge you? How are you, or your community, leaving the corners of your fields uncut?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who are you modeling the love and faith of Ruth for? In light of the world today, how can you bring others along with you in holding onto the good, ignoring other voices, and seeking hope?



WRESTLING

What questions remain about Ruth in the time of Judges? The history of Moab? How might this Story deepen our understanding of a cycle or redemption versus sin?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 2



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases that we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE

SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God. In Session 1, we encountered the idea of “Creating Space for God” in our lives. We believe that **if we do our part of creating that space, God will fill it** as He desires. You’re already doing this as you dive into the Text and jump into a place to discuss. God will meet you in these places! Look for places the Holy Spirit can do work in and through you as you go about your everyday life.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS

YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

***We believe that young adults are shaping the future of this world.** Jesus modeled a ministry of discipling young adults, and that approach has and will work. If you are a college student who is listening, we want this material to be directly helpful to your pursuits. If you are not a college student, we want to challenge you to come alongside one and work together.*

SACRED STATION

THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn’t only for church or Bible study; this is about what we do every day. How we do our job and how it may take advantage of or bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Justice is very much something God cares about. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Does it exploit creation? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can provide relief to others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***